

36 Bezalel

The craftsman God filled with his Spirit to build the tabernacle.

Bezalel was a craftsman from the tribe of Judah. At Mount Sinai, God called him by name to build the tabernacle, the tent where God would dwell among his people. He is the first person Scripture names as "filled ... with the spirit of God," and the Spirit gave him wisdom and skill in gold, silver, bronze, stone and wood. With his partner Aholiab and many skilled workers, he turned the people's generous gifts into the ark, the altars, the lampstand and the tent itself. Bezalel never speaks in Scripture, and he never leads a battle. His story shows that practical, creative work can be a calling from God.

At a glance

Name	Betsalel, "in the shadow of God"; KJV Bezaleel
Family	Son of Uri, son of Hur, of Judah (Exodus 31:2)
Role	Chief craftsman of the tabernacle (Exodus 31:1–5; 38:22)
Partner	Aholiab son of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan (Exodus 31:6; 38:23)
When	At Sinai, c. 1446–1445 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Main passages	Exodus 31:1–11; 35:30–38:23
New Testament	Not named

"See, I have called by name Bezaleel the son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah: And I have filled him with the spirit of God, in wisdom, and in understanding, and in knowledge, and in all manner of workmanship,"

Exodus 31:2–3, KJV

The life of Bezalel

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. The tabernacle was set up on the first day of the first month of the second year (Exodus 40:17).

- c. 1446 BC

At Sinai

●

Called by name

While Moses is on the mountain, God names Bezalel as the builder of the tabernacle and all its furnishings, with Aholiab to help him. *Exodus 31:1-11*
- c. 1446 BC

After the golden calf

●

Presented to the people

Moses tells Israel that the LORD has called Bezalel and filled him with his Spirit. God has also given him and Aholiab the ability to teach others. *Exodus 35:30-35*
- c. 1446 BC

At Sinai

●

Receives the gifts

The people bring freewill offerings every morning. Soon the workers report that there is more than enough, and Moses tells the people to stop giving. *Exodus 36:1-7*
- c. 1446-1445 BC

At Sinai

●

Builds

Bezalel and the skilled workers make the curtains, boards and veil. He makes the ark and mercy seat, the table, the lampstand, the altars and the laver. *Exodus 36:8-38:20*
- c. 1445 BC

Second year

●

The work is finished

The finished pieces are brought to Moses. He sees that everything is done as the LORD commanded and blesses the workers. The tabernacle is raised. *Exodus 38:22; 39:32-43; 40:17*

Group notes

Key activities

Some think Bezalel's grandfather Hur is the same Hur who held up Moses' hands (Exodus 17:10-12; 24:14). The text does not say, and Hur was a common name.

-
- 1 Was called by name.** God chose him personally for this work. *Exodus 31:2; 35:30*
 - 2 Was filled with the Spirit.** God gave him wisdom, understanding and knowledge for craftsmanship. *Exodus 31:3-5; 35:31-33*
 - 3 Taught others.** God put it in his heart to teach, along with Aholiab. *Exodus 35:34-35*
 - 4 Led a team.** He worked with Aholiab and "every wise hearted man" whom God had gifted. *Exodus 36:1-2, 8*
 - 5 Made the ark.** He made the ark of acacia wood overlaid with gold, the mercy seat, and the two cherubim. *Exodus 37:1-9*
 - 6 Made the furnishings.** He made the table, the golden lampstand, the incense altar, the anointing oil and the incense. *Exodus 37:10-29*
 - 7 Made the altar and laver.** He built the bronze altar, and he made the laver from the mirrors of the women who served at the door. *Exodus 38:1-8*
 - 8 Did everything as commanded.** He "made all that the LORD commanded Moses." *Exodus 38:22*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Bezalel.

Old Testament

Exodus 31:1–11	God calls and equips him
Exodus 35:30–38:23	He and the workers build the tabernacle
1 Chronicles 2:18–20	His family line in Judah
2 Chronicles 1:5	His bronze altar still at Gibeon in Solomon's day
Ezra 10:30	A different Bezaleel, after the exile
Echo: 1 Kings 7:13–14	Hiram, "filled with wisdom," works bronze for the temple

New Testament

Hebrews 8:5	and Acts 7:44. Moses made the tabernacle according to the pattern shown on the mountain.
Hebrews 9:1–5	The tabernacle and its furniture are described.
Echoes	The Spirit gives different gifts for the good of all (1 Corinthians 12:4–11). "Whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord" (Colossians 3:23).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does God use to describe the gifts he gave Bezalel (Exodus 31:3–5)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God filled a craftsman with his Spirit, not only prophets and leaders?
3. *Apply:* What practical skill has God given you? How could you use it to serve your church or neighbors this month?
4. *Apply:* Bezalel also taught others. Who could you train or encourage in a skill you have?